

Excerpt: [2003] "For decades, the United States has worshiped at the altar of a unified yet unnatural Iraqi state. Allowing all three communities within that false state to emerge at least as self-governing regions would be both difficult and dangerous. Washington would have to be very hard-headed, and hard-hearted, to engineer this breakup. But such a course is manageable, even necessary, because it would allow us to find Iraq's future in its denied but natural past."

Washington wasn't hard-headed or hard-hearted in engineering the partition of Iraq. Sometimes, stuff happens without Washington's involvement.

After Mosul, Iraq is effectively (in effect) partitioned into three main territorial regions. While the boundaries between Kurdistan and the Shia and Sunni regions are fairly well defined, more or less, the boundary between the Shia and Sunni regions remains a work in progress.

Excerpt: [2006] "The Sunnis, who until recently believed they would retake power in Iraq, are beginning to recognize that they won't and don't want to live in a Shiite-controlled, highly centralized state with laws enforced by sectarian militias. The Shiites know they can dominate the government, but they can't defeat a Sunni insurrection. The Kurds will not give up their 15-year-old autonomy."

Despite having a professionally-trained and well-equipped military, eight years later the Shia have reverted to sectarian militias to defend themselves against a Sunni insurrection.

Excerpt: [2014] "If the jihadis can be halted, then smashed – and it's critical to try to achieve that – the Iraqis must turn back to politics and the principle of power-sharing that they spurned not so long ago. For some time, Iraq and Syria will be torn apart by religious and tribal strife. These present circumstances provide barren ground for a settlement, but if the Iraqi Humpty Dumpty is to be made whole again, it can be only through a federal power-sharing formula."

IF!

It can't be said "Iraqis" spurned power-sharing. But it can be said that Iraqi Prime Minister Nuri al-Maliki and his closest supporters spurned power-sharing. While some Sunnis may still believe they are the majority in Iraq, others among the Sunni leadership are reasonable and have made efforts to participate in collective, inclusive government. This Sunni effort could have been taken farther, but that would have taken a different kind of leadership.

The Kurds have always promoted power-sharing, calling for autonomy within the framework of Iraq since at least the early 1960s. The call was repeated often enough. In an article on the peshmerga in the March 1975 issue of National Geographic magazine it was repeated yet again. In 1992, after regional elections led to the formation of the Iraqi Kurdistan Parliament (IKP) and Kurdistan Regional Government (KRG), the IKP passed a resolution calling for federalism within a democratic Iraq. In 2005, the Constitution of Iraq, passed overwhelmingly in a countrywide referendum, called for federalism, but it was not implemented.

What next?

Iraq is about rich cultural heritage, abundant natural resources, and tremendous potential to form a viable, peaceful, prosperous, and progressive country. Iraq is also about aggressively active divisions.

Inclusive leadership that meets the challenge of promoting national unity has yet to develop. Casualties (killed, wounded, disappeared), displacements, emigration, and disrupted lives are the norms of the day. Not always, but that's the way it is today and the future is not looking any brighter.

Within each of the three main regions there are active divisions working against each other, even in the Kurdistan Region. Efforts to effectively manage divisions varies from one region to another, the Kurdistan Region so far being the most successful.

Leslie H. Gelb, a former correspondent and columnist for The New York Times, is a past president of the Council on Foreign Relations that publishes the prestigious journal *Foreign Affairs*. In late 2003 he proposed a three-state solution for Iraq. In 2006 he, with then Senator Joe Biden, proposed a soft partitioning, "Decentralization is hardly as radical as it may seem: the Iraqi Constitution, in fact, already provides for a federal structure and a procedure for provinces to combine into regional governments."

Autonomy within the framework of Iraq was called for during the early 1960s and agreed to in 1970 between the Kurdish leadership and the Government of Iraq, but it was not satisfactorily implemented.

Federalism was called for by the IKP in 1992 and formally agreed to in 2005, but, again, it was not satisfactorily implemented.

Again, what next?

The New York Times
13 Jul 2014

Deadlock Blocks Iraqi Leadership Vote as ISIS Makes Gains Toward Baghdad

By ALISSA J. RUBIN and SUADAD AL-SALHY

BAGHDAD — As Iraq's deadlocked Parliament was again unable to reach a deal to name a new speaker on Sunday, Sunni militants carried out a raid near Baghdad, a symbolically significant attack signaling their intent to move closer, even if only by a few miles, toward the Iraqi capital.

Although the pretext for the delay was a severe sandstorm that prevented northern Iraq's Kurdish lawmakers from flying to Baghdad, the real reason appeared to be that last-minute deals between the largest Shiite bloc and the Sunnis were falling apart.

"We were ready, we came with our candidates, but the others haven't presented their candidates," said Usama al-Nujaifi, the Sunni lawmaker, who served as speaker in the last Parliament but has agreed not to run this time.

"The country is completely collapsing and we need to unify the nation — the delay means more killing, more displaced and more emigration," Mr. Nujaifi said.

However, what became clear over the last couple of days was a far more striking problem: Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki has not given up his campaign for a third term despite his widespread unpopularity among most Sunnis and Kurds and doubts from many of his fellow Shiites.

Iraq has a Shiite majority nationwide and by custom, since 2003 when Saddam Hussein was ousted, the prime minister's slot has been held by a Shiite. But there are a number of Shiite parties, including several Islamist ones, in addition to Mr. Maliki's party.

In several conversations with members of Mr. Maliki's larger State of Law coalition, which includes several Shiite parties, it was apparent that they had done the math and determined that he could pull it off. Thus there was no need for a new person.

"At the end, the Sunnis will accept the prime minister," said Sami al-Askari, a member of Parliament and a close supporter of Mr. Maliki from within the prime minister's party, Dawa.

"And also the Kurds will accept him — not Barzani, he has a problem, but the P.U.K. will," he said referring to the president of the Kurdistan region, Massoud Barzani, with whom Mr. Maliki has bitterly feuded over the prospect of a Kurdish referendum on separating from Iraq. The P.U.K. is the Patriotic Union of Kurdistan, another major Kurdish party, but it does not support the idea of independence from Iraq at this point.

Another political associate of Mr. Maliki, Walid al-Hilli, suggested that those close to the prime minister had counted the votes: 120 Shiites, including the roughly 95 from Mr. Maliki's State of Law coalition, would support him; about 35 Sunnis led by Salim al-Jubouri would join them; and so would about 25 Kurds. Mr. Maliki needs 165 votes to retain his job.

"There isn't any option other than Maliki," Mr. Hilli said.

But those assumptions were tested Sunday when it became clear that Mr. Jubouri might not support Mr. Maliki. The day before, Mr. Jubouri had signed a document in front of the bloc of Sunni lawmakers promising that in exchange for being named speaker, he would represent the wishes of the six provinces with significant Sunni populations, which now feel discriminated against by the central government and would not back Mr. Maliki for prime minister.

Mr. Maliki learned about the document overnight, and in a meeting with Shiites on Sunday he told them that this raised questions about whether he could support Mr. Jubouri, said several Shiites who attended the meeting.

"It was because of that the Parliament session was delayed and the National Alliance was discouraged about the prospect of voting" for Mr. Jubouri as speaker, said Aboud al-Essawi, a member of the coalition that supports Mr. Maliki.

For all the back and forth, the reality appeared to be that Mr. Maliki was having trouble gathering the votes needed to retain his post, and it seemed that Iraqi lawmakers, principally Shiite ones, were now grappling with how to deal with it.

"We're confused," said one longtime supporter of Mr. Maliki, when asked what the options would be if Mr. Maliki could not gather the votes.

Get Ready for Kurdish Independence

By ZALMAY KHALILZAD

WASHINGTON — In the coming weeks, Iraq's leaders must make existential decisions. If they cannot form a unity government led by a new prime minister and motivate Sunni moderates and tribes to fight the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria, Iraq is likely to disintegrate.

If the central government fails to grant satisfactory concessions to Sunnis and Kurds, the Kurds will push for sovereignty and independence. The Kurds are serious, and the international community must adapt to this emerging reality. While all Iraqi leaders bear responsibility for resolving the current crisis, the greatest share lies with the country's Shiite politicians, who dominate the central government. Shiite parties must select a candidate for prime minister who can share power, decentralize the government and depoliticize the security forces.

As a prerequisite for working with the central government, Kurdistan seeks the right to export its own oil; integrate Kirkuk and other recently acquired areas; settle past budget issues and keep its own autonomous finances; and maintain control of the region's Peshmerga security forces, including acquiring weapons to defend itself against ISIS.

The Kurds aren't confident that Baghdad will accept these demands and have initiated parallel preparations for independence. Massoud Barzani, the Kurdish president, has asked the region's parliament to establish an electoral commission and set a date to conduct a referendum.

Kurdistan's arguments for sovereignty are reasonable. It is different than Arab Iraq: it is more stable, more prosperous and more tolerant. Baghdad is unable to protect its people, and won't be able to do so for the foreseeable future. Close to one million Iraqis, including many Christians, have taken refuge there.

In the wake of ISIS advances, Kurdistan now shares a 600-mile border with a terrorist entity that proclaims itself the new Islamic Caliphate. In order to defend itself, the Kurds must be able to acquire their own arms and maintain security relations with other nations. Baghdad has suspended budget payments to Kurdistan. To pay its bills, Kurdistan must therefore sell its oil.

For years, Iraq's Shiite-led government has failed to treat Sunnis or Kurds as equal partners. Many Sunnis now so profoundly oppose the government that they have aligned themselves with a terrorist organization that even Al Qaeda considers extremist. The Sunnis demand federalization and autonomy for their provinces, an end to de-Ba'athification, and the delegation of local security to local forces.

For their part, the Kurds were incorporated into Iraq against their will, and endured much of the 20th century under repressive, often murderous, rule. In recent weeks, Kurdish leaders have launched a major diplomatic initiative, both regionally and internationally, to promote their dual-track approach to independence.

As Washington adapts to the new reality on the ground, it would do well to adopt a similar two-pronged strategy: continue to help Iraq's leaders forge a unity government, but prepare for the failure of those efforts.

Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki, whose parliamentary bloc emerged victorious in the April 30 election, has no intention of giving up power. The major obstacle to the formation of a unity government is the vehement opposition of Sunni Arabs, Kurds, and some Shiite parties to prolonging Mr. Maliki's rule. Iraq's senior Shiite cleric, Grand Ayatollah Ali al-Sistani, has also signaled his preference for change.

As the American ambassador to Iraq, I worked directly with Mr. Maliki, and I know that he will stubbornly resist attempts to replace him. If he ultimately agrees to step down, he will likely demand a guarantee that his successor be chosen from among a small, trusted circle; he may also insist on a position elsewhere in the government.

Absent the formation of a unity government, Iraq's civil war will continue unabated. Sectarian conflict, and chaos in the Sunnis areas, will grow — and so will ISIS. Shiites will become more reliant on sectarian militias, and on Iran.

This trajectory threatens America's security. The United States must continue to work for a unity government in Iraq, and extend limited assistance in the fight against ISIS. But it should also step up relations with Kurdistan by deploying a team to assess Kurdistan's needs and coordinate security strategies to protect the region against ISIS. To help Kurdistan pay its bills, Washington should soften its opposition to direct Kurdish oil sales while increasing humanitarian assistance for refugees and displaced persons there.

The coming weeks will be decisive. The best-case scenario would be the establishment of a decentralized Iraq with a federal system in the Arab-majority areas, operating in confederation with Kurdistan. The alternative is civil war between Shiites and Sunnis, and the emergence of an independent Kurdistan.

Although Washington shouldn't abandon its efforts to help Iraq form a unity government yet, it must think seriously about realistic alternatives if Iraq falls apart.

Whatever happens, strengthening ties with Kurdistan now will serve American interests down the road.

Zalmay Khalilzad, the president of Gryphon Partners, was the United States ambassador to Iraq from 2005 to 2007.

The New York Times
8 Jul 2014

Iraqi Lawmakers to Reconvene in Effort to Form Government

By ALISSA J. RUBIN

BAGHDAD — The Iraqi Parliament on Tuesday set its next meeting for Sunday as it tries again to form a new government after a failed attempt last week.

While the effort to form a government continued, fighting in northern and western Sunni provinces continued with no decisive movement on either side, but with airstrikes on Sunni militant positions in Tikrit and moves by militants to take more villages in northeastern Salahuddin Province.

It was unclear whether there would be any progress on Sunday or enough lawmakers present to form a quorum.

Parliament's administrative office had told lawmakers on Monday that there would be no session until Aug. 12. That announcement was met with dismay by other nations, which have been urging Iraq to act quickly to form a government that reflects the country's diverse and often hostile religious sects and ethnic groups.

On Tuesday, the temporary speaker, Mahdi al-Hafith, announced that Parliament would attempt to meet on Sunday "in order to safeguard the public interest and continue to build democracy."

The first step under the Constitution is to elect a speaker, and within a month to name a president and two vice presidents. Two weeks after that, Parliament is required to choose a prime minister.

Though elected in April, Parliament has not yet formed a government, in part because there is antagonism toward Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki. There now seems to be a focused effort to remove Mr. Maliki and find an acceptable alternative. Mr. Maliki, however, is pursuing a third term and is using his position as commander in chief to portray himself as crucial to holding the army together.

There is no consensus candidate yet for prime minister.

In northern and western Iraq, both the Sunni militants led by the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, or ISIS, and Iraqi government forces attempted to make gains.

In Tikrit, the capital of Salahuddin Province, Iraqi forces bombed buildings they believed were ISIS positions, but also dropped leaflets urging Tikritis to support them and fight ISIS.

In Al Qaim, on the western Iraqi border with Syria, three witnesses said they saw a drone fly in from Syria and drop a bomb on the military headquarters in the town. In Samarra, a town north of Baghdad, a suicide bomber detonated himself near the headquarters of the security command center, killing five people and wounding four others, according to an officer in the command center.

The United Nations also made public on Tuesday a letter from the Iraqi ambassador to the United Nations that said the government had lost a former chemical weapons facility to "armed terrorist groups."

The New York Times
7 Jul 2014

Iraqi Parliament Wobbles Over Forming Government

By ALISSA J. RUBIN and SUADAD AL-SALHY

Iraq's political process appeared near collapse for several hours on Monday after the Parliament said it would be at least five weeks before members would even try to elect a speaker, the first step in the process of forming a government.

But that plan appeared to be in flux after a firestorm of criticism from friendly countries and senior Shiite clerics, and late Monday evening Parliament said members would try to meet Sunday — only five days later than originally planned.

The announcement of the five-week delay was quickly followed by charges and countercharges about which political bloc was to blame for slowing down the political process. And even if Parliament does meet Sunday and chooses a speaker, it is far from clear that it will be able to move speedily to the next steps of selecting a president, two vice presidents and a prime minister.

"It's a crisis," said Laith Kubba, an analyst who served as a spokesman for the Iraqi government shortly after the fall of former President Saddam Hussein.

"The problem is that there is no shared vision today in Iraq," Mr. Kubba said. "The Kurds have developed a vision, and the Sunnis are very confused about the new reality, and the Shia are very confused."

The election was held in April but it was not certified until mid-June, and when Parliament met for the first time last week, all members could agree on was delaying for a week. According to the Iraqi Constitution, the first step is to name a speaker and once that is done, lawmakers have a maximum of two weeks to choose a president and two vice presidents and then a month more to choose the prime minister.

Since a large part of the country was taken over by Sunni extremists on June 10, touching off the current crisis, a host of friendly governments — most prominently, the United States and Iran — have urged Parliament to move quickly to form a unity government that might give the country a new direction and forestall further political fraying.

They have pushed the Shiite majority government to reach out to Sunnis, who say they have been treated as second-class citizens, imprisoned in large numbers and disadvantaged directly and indirectly by the Shiite-dominated government led by Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki.

Critics of the Maliki government say that its relentlessly sectarian policies alienated Sunnis, helping to ease the way for the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria to oust the Iraqi Army and move into Sunni areas in Iraq's north and west. In the melee, the Kurds seized other disputed areas in the north with the result that the country's borders are being redrawn on the ground, something that many Iraqi lawmakers seem not to have fully faced.

Instead, much of the public discussion has been about assigning blame for not forming the government, while there is almost certainly considerable bargaining going on behind closed doors about what each bloc needs to sign on to the leadership slate.

"The session was postponed until Aug. 12 because of the disagreement and the conflict between the blocs," said Aboud al-Essawi, a member of Mr. Maliki's predominantly Shiite State of Law party, referring to other political parties.

The Sunnis said they were ready to proceed, but wanted the Shiites to make the first move. "We are still saying that we are ready to present our candidate for speaker whenever the National Alliance presents its candidate for prime minister, and it can be anyone else but not Maliki," said Dafar al-Ani, a spokesman for the main Sunni bloc, referring to a coalition of Shiite parties.

"The National Alliance asked for more time to make their final decision," he added.

Beneath the blame game are real differences in what is acceptable to different groups. For instance, a large number of Shiites now want to remove Mr. Maliki, but his party won the most parliamentary seats, so he cannot be summarily kicked aside. And there are differences of opinion about who might be an acceptable successor, first to all the Shiite blocs, but then also to the Sunnis and the Kurds.

Mr. Maliki says that removing him just as Iraq is trying to reconstitute its demoralized army would undermine those in the fight. While that might seem a convenient argument to prolong his time in power, at least some lawmakers appear to agree.

Even a senior leader in the Islamic Supreme Council of Iraq, a Shiite party that now opposes Mr. Maliki, said that "replacing Maliki now could be seen as a victory for the terrorists, and it also could adversely reflect the security leadership's morale because if Maliki is not there anymore, they could be dismissed or accused of corruption."

The Sunnis are demanding an amnesty for the tens of thousands of Sunni imprisoned — unjustly, they say, in most cases — by the Maliki government and a bigger say in how the country is run, including its security services. While some Shiites might be willing to give that to them, others are adamantly opposed.

The Kurds believe they have an absolute right to include Kirkuk and some surrounding disputed villages in the autonomous Kurdish region, but neither the Sunnis nor the Shiites want to cede that ground, especially since the Kurds have made it plain that their ultimate goal is independence.

While each group has defensible reasons for its views, taken together they amount to stasis.

In Washington on Monday, the State Department urged the Iraqi politicians to quickly form a new government.

"We're looking at a dire situation on the ground," said Jen Psaki, the State Department spokeswoman. "We've seen the statements," she added, referring to Parliament's schedule. "Our view is, that's not set in stone, that they still have the ability to move forward more quickly than what they outlined this morning."

In the meantime, the fight by the extremists goes on. The general commanding the Iraqi Army's Sixth Division was killed in a mortar attack on Monday morning west of Baghdad, according to officers in the division and a counterterrorism official.

The commander, Brig. Gen. Najim Abdullah Ali al-Sudani, was killed in or near the town of Garma, which is close to Fallujah, a city that has been held by Sunni militants for most of this year. In recent weeks, Iraqi troops bolstered by militia groups have been trying to reclaim the city.

The New York Times

7 Jul 2014

Iraq — or Sunnistan, Shiitestan and Kurdistan

By JAKE FLANAGIN

When the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria launched its 2014 assault on Iraq, the ensuing chaos ignited familiar discussions about the future of the country and the possibility of a “three-state solution.”

In 2013, Robin Wright analyzed a redrawn map of the Middle East in *The New York Times*, pointing out how 5 countries could “become 14” in the future. These hypotheses appear more prescient than ever.

To begin, the prospect of Kurdish independence is one of the “worst-kept secrets” in the Middle East, writes Simon Tisdall for *The Guardian*. “Saddam Hussein’s fall in 2003 brought the Kurdish region in northern Iraq a significant measure of self-rule, building on its precarious post-1991 autonomy,” Mr. Tisdall says. “The Kurdish regional government (KRG) has steadily expanded its political and economic clout over the past decade. Now the apparent collapse of central authority in Iraq has given the biggest boost yet to the independence movement.”

It’s a push that President Abdel Fattah el-Sisi of Egypt calls potentially “catastrophic.” According to Reuters, the Middle East News Agency quoted Mr. Sisi as describing the possibility as “no more than the start of a catastrophic division of Iraq into smaller rival states,” which will ultimately add fuel to the blaze of extremist insurgency gripping the region.

Bashdar Pusho Ismaeel, a columnist for *The Kurdish Globe*, an English-language newspaper based in the northern Iraqi city of Erbil, disagrees: “From a Kurdish perspective, it is a question of how can you break something that wasn’t whole to start with?”

“Who can blame the Kurds, who never wanted to be a part of the Iraqi state in the first place, to push for separation when the country is yet again in sectarian flames?” he asks. “Even Turkey, traditionally a staunch opponent of Kurdish nationalism, has come to realise that not only is Kurdish independence a natural path that ultimately cannot be stopped, but they can gain tremendous benefit from a secular, oil rich, strategic partner in the tumultuous new age of the Middle East.”

In an Op-Ed for *The New York Times*, Leslie H. Gelb, president emeritus of the Council on Foreign Relations, explained that a disintegrated Iraq could be a disaster: “Such a rupture would ignite terrible slaughter inside the country and unsettle the Middle East as a whole.” Mr. Gelb recognizes the political impossibility of a wholly united Iraq and instead advocates

increased federalization as a solution for national and regional peace: "If the Iraqi Humpty Dumpty is to be made whole again, it can be only through a federal power-sharing formula."

Mr. Gelb recalled an article written for The Times in 2006, which he wrote with Vice President Joseph R. Biden Jr., then a Delaware senator. It was one of the first major appeals for a federalized Iraq. "Establish three largely autonomous regions with a viable central government in Baghdad," Mr. Biden and Mr. Gelb wrote. "The Kurdish, Sunni and Shiite regions would each be responsible for their own domestic laws, administration and internal security. The central government would control border defense, foreign affairs and oil revenues. Baghdad would become a federal zone, while densely populated areas of mixed populations would receive both multisectarian and international police protection."

Those designs were dismissed. Speaking with The Washington Post's Adam Taylor, Mr. Gelb described the current situation in Iraq as "the worst of all possible worlds — anarchy!"

"Gelb has long maintained that he and Biden never said they supported partitioning Iraq, as their critics suggested," Mr. Taylor writes. A partition "destroys the economic viability of the territories," Mr. Gelb told him. "It creates a permanent warfare among the sections."

Perhaps there is a way to accomplish both partition and peace, Michael O'Hanlon and Edward P. Joseph suggest at Reuters. "The fundamental U.S. and European goal in Iraq now is neither an intact Iraq nor a partitioned one. We can live with either outcome," they explain. "The important objective is the defeat of the Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant (or ISIL), the terrorist group that now controls large swaths of both Syria and Iraq with its extreme brutality, its strong allegiances to an Al Qaeda-like ideology and its ambitions to do even more damage in the region and beyond."

"To defeat this group, the West needs the moderate Sunni leaders of Iraq to turn against the Sunni militants and take the lead in the fight, working with the United States through whatever military means we ultimately decide to provide," they write. But this is not especially feasible if moderate Sunni leaders "wind up living in a rump state of 'Sunnistan,' created by battlefield realities, not political accord, lacking natural resources, unfunded by the central state of Iraq and with significant numbers of their fellow Sunnis still living in diverse cities like Baghdad, where they could be vulnerable to possible Shiite pogroms."

"To be effective, partition needs to be carefully managed and fair," Mr. O'Hanlon and Mr. Joseph clarify. "A Sunni-majority region, to parallel the Kurdish autonomous zone (or a new Kurdish independent state), could perhaps begin slightly north and west of Baghdad and extend up to Mosul in the north and include towns like Fallujah and Ramadi on the way to the Syrian border in the west." Regardless of whether Sunnistan, Shiitistan and Kurdistan operate autonomously or as sovereign states, the essential political asset for the region is inter-ethnic and sectarian cooperation.

"In the end, what is needed is a joint campaign plan for defeating the Islamist militants that is developed and supported by the United States and the region, but led by Iraqi Shiite and Sunni and Kurds," Mr. O'Hanlon and Mr. Joseph write. "That remains the ultimate and nonnegotiable objective."

Kurdish Officials Seek More Autonomy in Any Deal With a New Government

By MICHAEL R. GORDON and ALISSA J. RUBIN

WASHINGTON — Senior Kurdish officials served notice on Thursday that Kurdistan would not participate in a new Iraqi government unless Baghdad grants it expanded autonomy and does not insist on reversing their occupation of Kirkuk.

“We are going to give once again a chance to the political process in Baghdad, but we are not going to think that is the only path,” said Fuad Hussein, the chief of staff to Massoud Barzani, the president of the Kurdish autonomous region.

“Parallel to that we are going to build ourselves, and we are heading toward exercising self-determination,” Mr. Hussein added before he went to the White House to see Vice President Joseph R. Biden Jr. and Antony Blinken, the deputy national security adviser.

Mr. Hussein’s comments came as Mr. Barzani asked the Kurdish Parliament, in a closed-door speech, to organize a referendum on independence, a move that caused dismay among Sunni and Shiite politicians in Baghdad.

Secretary of State John Kerry has urged the Kurds to play a leading role in forming a unified government in Baghdad and to defer their dreams of independence. Or as Mr. Kerry put it in a meeting with the Kurdish president in Erbil last week, “this moment requires statesmanship.”

That was a message that Jen Psaki, the State Department spokeswoman, emphasized this week: “We’ve been very consistent and clear about our view that a stronger Iraq is a united Iraq, a united Iraq is a stronger Iraq.”

But there was no indication in comments by Mr. Hussein or Falah Mustafa Bakir, the head of Kurdistan’s foreign affairs department, that the Kurds were merely seeking leverage for the negotiations in Baghdad or shelving their desire for statehood.

While the Kurdish officials referred to self-determination as a step the Kurds might take if the process of government formation in Baghdad fails, they also expressed doubts that the negotiations with their Sunni and Shiite counterparts would succeed.

“Are they going to recognize the new reality in Iraq?” said Mr. Hussein, referring to Sunni and Shiite politicians who are struggling to form a government after Sunni militants captured much of western and northern Iraq and Kurdish pesh merga fighters moved to occupy and defend territories long disputed between Arabs and Kurds. That recognition, he added, would entail “recognizing the border of Kurdistan” and “recognizing the independence of our economy.”

“These are questions which we will raise and we need answers,” Mr. Hussein said. “If they cannot give answers,” the Kurds would make their own decisions on “the future of Kurdistan.”

Indeed, one purpose of holding talks in Baghdad, Mr. Hussein said, may ultimately be to negotiate the terms of the “divorce” between Kurdistan and Iraq.

“We have never been treated equally; nor have we been treated as a partner,” Mr. Bakir said.

After the White House meeting, Mr. Biden's office issued a statement asserting that both sides had “agreed on the importance of forming a new government in Iraq that will pull together all communities” and can counter the threat posed by the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria.

Mr. Barzani's speech to the Kurdish Parliament was closed to the public, and reporters received accounts from Kurdish lawmakers who attended it

Mr. Barzani has stated unequivocally that he does not plan to give up Kirkuk, a city in northern Iraq that sits on substantial oil reserves. While nothing in his speech on Thursday appeared to go beyond his previous comments on Kirkuk, the insistent drumbeat that the Kurds would not cede Kirkuk and other disputed areas and planned to move toward independence made clear that a de facto partition of the country could really happen.

In Baghdad, Haider al-Abadi, an influential member of Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki's Shiite State of Law party, said that Mr. Barzani appeared to be seeking leverage for the negotiations in Baghdad.

“Barzani is looking to get all the elements of a state without declaring a state,” Mr. Abadi said. “He is taking everything without giving anything.”

The goals of the three main groups in Iraq — Sunni, Shiite and Kurdish — as the country threatens to split apart along sectarian lines.

Even Sunni lawmakers, who have expressed sympathy for the Kurds' frustration with Mr. Maliki's government, said they were deeply worried because it is principally Sunnis who live near the Kurdish border who would be affected if Kurdistan became an independent entity, especially if that entity included disputed areas. Sunnis, who were forcibly moved to the region more than 40 years ago as an effort by the Saddam Hussein regime to mix Iraq's sects, fear becoming marginalized as well as losing a claim to the area's oil wealth.

“We hope that the Kurds' leader will not take a step which could have an impact on their partners without taking them into account,” said Dafar al-Ani, a leader of a new coalition of Sunnis in the Iraqi Parliament.

“We have a rooted belief in the Kurds' rights,” he said, adding, “We do not deny the oppression that the Kurds faced for decades, and we are aware that they still have problems with the central authorities, but we hope that our brother Massoud will not take any fateful decisions which could impact his partners without discussions.”

Kurdish lawmakers by contrast sounded a note of certainty after the speech, although they asserted that any decision would be made by the Parliament as well as the Kurdish leadership.

“Barzani will not make a decision alone,” said Haj Karwan, a Kurdish Parliament member. “The Kurdish Parliament will have the final word on the future of Kurdistan, but our armed forces will not retreat, and we will stay in Kirkuk to protect everyone,” he said, repeating, almost exactly, Mr. Barzani’s words.

The New York Times
1 Jul 2014

Iraq Must Not Come Apart

By LESLIE H. GELB

“For decades, the United States has worshiped at the altar of a unified yet unnatural Iraqi state.” I wrote these words in November 2003, six months after President George W. Bush declared “Mission accomplished.” I described the outcome of what I saw as the splintering of Iraq into Sunni, Shiite and Kurdish regions as “The Three-State Solution.” This thinking — once again inflaming policy debates — seemed to me the only way to avoid the internecine tribal and religious war again underway.

Middle East experts dismissed the idea as a partition policy. My intent was not to advocate a policy, but to describe what I thought was the inevitable breakup of Iraq. I urged the United States to make this as peaceable as possible. It was my hope that these states would eventually form a loose confederation.

It appeared that the experts had strangled my idea in the cradle until a strange thing happened to me on the New York to Washington shuttle in 2006. Senator Joseph R. Biden Jr. took a seat next to me, and while the plane idled on the runway, we talked about Iraq.

Mr. Biden and I agreed on the following principle: We didn’t want a breakup or partitioning of Iraq. Such a rupture would ignite terrible slaughter inside the country and unsettle the Middle East as a whole. Alas, my 2003 article lent itself to the partition criticism, even though it saw autonomous regions as a possible solution, and Mr. Biden and I wanted to clarify that point.

At the same time, however, we still had to stress our belief that the fragmenting of Iraq was inevitable unless each religious and tribal group had strong incentives to stay in a unified state. For us, there was only one policy glue: federalism, or the decentralization of power to the regions with a limited role for central government. Though different in the particulars, the same idea provided the freedom of action for the original 13 colonies to form the United States of America.

In 2006, Mr. Biden and I wrote, also in an Op-Ed for The New York Times, that any stability in a united Iraq would be contingent upon an American troop presence that should not and could not be indefinitely sustained. Sunni dictatorships had held the country together in the past, but provided no long-term answers to the country’s challenges. We proposed instead that Kurdish, Sunni and Shiite regions “each be responsible for their own domestic laws, administration and internal security.” Baghdad would be declared a federal zone, and the central government there would be tasked with controlling defense, foreign affairs and the equitable distribution of oil revenues.

Despite all the criticism at the time, the Iraqis themselves embedded this approach in their Constitution. Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki never implemented it, but rather sought to give his fellow Shiites the absolute power historically wielded by the Sunnis.

The question now is whether federalism is still feasible, or even desirable. Back in 2003, and still in 2006, Washington had the sway in arms and aid to have federalism implemented. Current American influence is limited, and President Obama's clout will depend less on what American force he brings to bear in the current crisis than on what strategy he offers.

Sadly, he doesn't seem to have one.

Let me offer a strategy that prioritizes fighting the jihadis now and pushes for federalism later. The most urgent task is to prevent further conquest by the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, or ISIS.

Iraqi armed forces, despite their military superiority, can't do this job alone. They just don't have the stomach for such a fight. They must have outside aid, and they are already getting some from Iran, and now Russia.

This is helpful, but not enough. More Iranian aid should be the subject of urgent talks among Tehran, Baghdad and Washington. The risk is that Iran could get grabby, but I believe it will be restrained by its central objective of easing the United States-led sanctions.

The second step of this strategy is to set President Bashar al-Assad of Syria against the jihadis in Iraq, an offensive he started on his own with airstrikes last week. This would acknowledge the reality of Iraq and Syria as one strategic, anti-jihadi battlefield.

But instead of capitalizing on Mr. Assad's anti-jihadi instincts, the Obama team now proposes to do what it has resisted doing for almost three years — to send hundreds of millions of dollars in arms aid for the Sunni rebels battling the Assad government. This move has American priorities backward. It will turn Mr. Assad away from the jihadis in Iraq, and back to fighting American-backed rebels in Syria.

The greatest threat to American interests in the region is ISIS, not Mr. Assad. To fight this enemy, Mr. Obama needs to call on others similarly threatened: Iran, Russia, Iraqi Shiites and Kurds, Jordan, Turkey — and above all, the political leader with the best-armed forces in the region, Mr. Assad. Part of the deal would need to be that the Syrian regime and the rebels largely leave each other alone.

If the jihadis can be halted, then smashed — and it's critical to try to achieve that — the Iraqis must turn back to politics and the principle of power-sharing that they spurned not so long ago. For some time, Iraq and Syria will be torn apart by religious and tribal strife. These present circumstances provide barren ground for a settlement, but if the Iraqi Humpty Dumpty is to be made whole again, it can be only through a federal power-sharing formula.

The Obama team knows that Iraqis will not trust Mr. Maliki to share power seriously. They are maneuvering to find alternatives. It will be more difficult than ever to persuade Iraqi Sunnis to accept a federal Iraq, given recent history; even the Kurds seem inclined to go their own way.

Words will not bring Iraqis over from the separatist dark side. Only the hell of civil war can bring them back, in time, to political solutions. And only then can Washington help the Iraqis do what they should have done a decade ago.

Leslie H. Gelb, a former correspondent and columnist for The New York Times, is the president emeritus of the Council on Foreign Relations.

The New York times
May 1, 2006

Unity Through Autonomy in Iraq

By JOSEPH R. BIDEN JR. and LESLIE H. GELB

A decade ago, Bosnia was torn apart by ethnic cleansing and facing its demise as a single country. After much hesitation, the United States stepped in decisively with the Dayton Accords, which kept the country whole by, paradoxically, dividing it into ethnic federations, even allowing Muslims, Croats and Serbs to retain separate armies. With the help of American and other forces, Bosnians have lived a decade in relative peace and are now slowly strengthening their common central government, including disbanding those separate armies last year.

Now the Bush administration, despite its profound strategic misjudgments in Iraq, has a similar opportunity. To seize it, however, America must get beyond the present false choice between "staying the course" and "bringing the troops home now" and choose a third way that would wind down our military presence responsibly while preventing chaos and preserving our key security goals.

The idea, as in Bosnia, is to maintain a united Iraq by decentralizing it, giving each ethno-religious group — Kurd, Sunni Arab and Shiite Arab — room to run its own affairs, while leaving the central government in charge of common interests. We could drive this in place with irresistible sweeteners for the Sunnis to join in, a plan designed by the military for withdrawing and redeploying American forces, and a regional nonaggression pact.

It is increasingly clear that President Bush does not have a strategy for victory in Iraq. Rather, he hopes to prevent defeat and pass the problem along to his successor. Meanwhile, the frustration of Americans is mounting so fast that Congress might end up mandating a rapid pullout, even at the risk of precipitating chaos and a civil war that becomes a regional war.

As long as American troops are in Iraq in significant numbers, the insurgents can't win and we can't lose. But intercommunal violence has surpassed the insurgency as the main security threat. Militias rule swathes of Iraq and death squads kill dozens daily. Sectarian cleansing has recently forced tens of thousands from their homes. On top of this, President Bush did not request additional reconstruction assistance and is slashing funds for groups promoting democracy.

Iraq's new government of national unity will not stop the deterioration. Iraqis have had three such governments in the last three years, each with Sunnis in key posts, without noticeable effect. The alternative path out of this terrible trap has five elements.

The first is to establish three largely autonomous regions with a viable central government in Baghdad. The Kurdish, Sunni and Shiite regions would each be responsible for their own domestic laws, administration and internal security. The central government would control border defense, foreign affairs and oil revenues. Baghdad would become a federal zone, while densely populated areas of mixed populations would receive both multisectarian and international police protection.

Decentralization is hardly as radical as it may seem: the Iraqi Constitution, in fact, already provides for a federal structure and a procedure for provinces to combine into regional governments.

Besides, things are already heading toward partition: increasingly, each community supports federalism, if only as a last resort. The Sunnis, who until recently believed they would retake power in Iraq, are beginning to recognize that they won't and don't want to live in a Shiite-controlled, highly centralized state with laws enforced by sectarian militias. The Shiites know they can dominate the government, but they can't defeat a Sunni insurrection. The Kurds will not give up their 15-year-old autonomy.

Some will say moving toward strong regionalism would ignite sectarian cleansing. But that's exactly what is going on already, in ever-bigger waves. Others will argue that it would lead to partition. But a breakup is already under way. As it was in Bosnia, a strong federal system is a viable means to prevent both perils in Iraq.

The second element would be to entice the Sunnis into joining the federal system with an offer they couldn't refuse. To begin with, running their own region should be far preferable to the alternatives: being dominated by Kurds and Shiites in a central government or being the main victims of a civil war. But they also have to be given money to make their oil-poor region viable. The Constitution must be amended to guarantee Sunni areas 20 percent (approximately their proportion of the population) of all revenues.

The third component would be to ensure the protection of the rights of women and ethno-religious minorities by increasing American aid to Iraq but tying it to respect for those rights. Such protections will be difficult, especially in the Shiite-controlled south, but Washington has to be clear that widespread violations will stop the cash flow.

Fourth, the president must direct the military to design a plan for withdrawing and redeploying our troops from Iraq by 2008 (while providing for a small but effective residual force to combat terrorists and keep the neighbors honest). We must avoid a precipitous withdrawal that would lead to a national meltdown, but we also can't have a substantial long-term American military presence. That would do terrible damage to our armed forces, break American and Iraqi public support for the mission and leave Iraqis without any incentive to shape up.

Fifth, under an international or United Nations umbrella, we should convene a regional conference to pledge respect for Iraq's borders and its federal system. For all that Iraq's neighbors might gain by picking at its pieces, each faces the greater danger of a regional war. A "contact group" of major powers would be set up to lean on neighbors to comply with the deal.

Mr. Bush has spent three years in a futile effort to establish a strong central government in Baghdad, leaving us without a real political settlement, with a deteriorating security situation — and with nothing but the most difficult policy choices. The five-point alternative plan

offers a plausible path to that core political settlement among Iraqis, along with the economic, military and diplomatic levers to make the political solution work. It is also a plausible way for Democrats and Republicans alike to protect our basic security interests and honor our country's sacrifices.

Joseph R. Biden Jr., Democrat of Delaware, is the ranking member of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee. Leslie H. Gelb is the president emeritus of the Council on Foreign Relations.

The New York Times
November 25, 2003
Op-Ed Contributor

The Three-State Solution

By LESLIE H. GELB

President Bush's new strategy of transferring power quickly to Iraqis, and his critics' alternatives, share a fundamental flaw: all commit the United States to a unified Iraq, artificially and fatefully made whole from three distinct ethnic and sectarian communities. That has been possible in the past only by the application of overwhelming and brutal force.

President Bush wants to hold Iraq together by conducting democratic elections countrywide. But by his daily reassurances to the contrary, he only fans devastating rumors of an American pullout. Meanwhile, influential senators have called for more and better American troops to defeat the insurgency. Yet neither the White House nor Congress is likely to approve sending more troops.

And then there is the plea, mostly from outside the United States government, to internationalize the occupation of Iraq. The moment for multilateralism, however, may already have passed. Even the United Nations shudders at such a nightmarish responsibility.

The only viable strategy, then, may be to correct the historical defect and move in stages toward a three-state solution: Kurds in the north, Sunnis in the center and Shiites in the south.

Almost immediately, this would allow America to put most of its money and troops where they would do the most good quickly, with the Kurds and Shiites. The United States could extricate most of its forces from the so-called Sunni Triangle, north and west of Baghdad, largely freeing American forces from fighting a costly war they might not win. American officials could then wait for the troublesome and domineering Sunnis, without oil or oil revenues, to moderate their ambitions or suffer the consequences.

This three-state solution has been unthinkable in Washington for decades. After the Iranian revolution in 1979, a united Iraq was thought necessary to counter an anti-American Iran. Since the gulf war in 1991, a whole Iraq was deemed essential to preventing neighbors like Turkey, Syria and Iran from picking at the pieces and igniting wider wars.

But times have changed. The Kurds have largely been autonomous for years, and Ankara has lived with that. So long as the Kurds don't move precipitously toward statehood or incite

insurgencies in Turkey or Iran, these neighbors will accept their autonomy. It is true that a Shiite self-governing region could become a theocratic state or fall into an Iranian embrace. But for now, neither possibility seems likely.

There is a hopeful precedent for a three-state strategy: Yugoslavia after World War II. In 1946, Marshal Tito pulled together highly disparate ethnic groups into a united Yugoslavia. A Croat himself, he ruled the country from Belgrade among the majority and historically dominant Serbs. Through clever politics and personality, Tito kept the peace peacefully.

When Tito died in 1980, several parts of Yugoslavia quickly declared their independence. The Serbs, with superior armed forces and the arrogance of traditional rulers, struck brutally against Bosnian Muslims and Croats.

Europeans and Americans protested but, stunningly and unforgivably, did little at first to prevent the violence. Eventually they gave the Bosnian Muslims and Croats the means to fight back, and the Serbs accepted separation. Later, when Albanians in the Serb province of Kosovo rebelled against their cruel masters, the United States and Europe had to intervene again. The result there will be either autonomy or statehood for Kosovo.

The lesson is obvious: overwhelming force was the best chance for keeping Yugoslavia whole, and even that failed in the end. Meantime, the costs of preventing the natural states from emerging had been terrible.

The ancestors of today's Shiites, Sunnis and Kurds have been in Mesopotamia since before modern history. The Shiites there, unlike Shiites elsewhere in the Arab world, are a majority. The Sunnis of the region gravitate toward pan-Arabism. The non-Arab Kurds speak their own language and have always fed their own nationalism.

The Ottomans ruled all the peoples of this land as they were: separately. In 1921, Winston Churchill cobbled the three parts together for oil's sake under a monarch backed by British armed forces. The Baathist Party took over in the 1960's, with Saddam Hussein consolidating its control in 1979, maintaining unity through terror and with occasional American help.

Today, the Sunnis have a far greater stake in a united Iraq than either the Kurds or the Shiites. Central Iraq is largely without oil, and without oil revenues, the Sunnis would soon become poor cousins.

The Shiites might like a united Iraq if they controlled it, which they could if those elections Mr. Bush keeps promising ever occur. But the Kurds and Sunnis are unlikely to accept Shiite control, no matter how democratically achieved. The Kurds have the least interest in any strong central authority, which has never been good for them.

A strategy of breaking up Iraq and moving toward a three-state solution would build on these realities. The general idea is to strengthen the Kurds and Shiites and weaken the Sunnis, then wait and see whether to stop at autonomy or encourage statehood.

The first step would be to make the north and south into self-governing regions, with boundaries drawn as closely as possible along ethnic lines. Give the Kurds and Shiites the bulk of the billions of dollars voted by Congress for reconstruction. In return, require

democratic elections within each region, and protections for women, minorities and the news media.

Second and at the same time, draw down American troops in the Sunni Triangle and ask the United Nations to oversee the transition to self-government there. This might take six to nine months; without power and money, the Sunnis may cause trouble.

For example, they might punish the substantial minorities left in the center, particularly the large Kurdish and Shiite populations in Baghdad. These minorities must have the time and the wherewithal to organize and make their deals, or go either north or south. This would be a messy and dangerous enterprise, but the United States would and should pay for the population movements and protect the process with force.

The Sunnis could also ignite insurgencies in the Kurdish and Shiite regions. To counter this, the United States would already have redeployed most of its troops north and south of the Sunni Triangle, where they could help arm and train the Kurds and Shiites, if asked.

The third part of the strategy would revolve around regional diplomacy. All the parties will suspect the worst of one another, not without reason. They will all need assurances about security. And if the three self-governing regions were to be given statehood, it should be done only with the consent of their neighbors. The Sunnis might surprise and behave well, thus making possible a single and loose confederation. Or maybe they would all have to live with simple autonomy, much as Taiwan does with respect to China.

For decades, the United States has worshiped at the altar of a unified yet unnatural Iraqi state. Allowing all three communities within that false state to emerge at least as self-governing regions would be both difficult and dangerous. Washington would have to be very hard-headed, and hard-hearted, to engineer this breakup. But such a course is manageable, even necessary, because it would allow us to find Iraq's future in its denied but natural past.

Leslie H. Gelb, a former editor and columnist for The Times, is president emeritus of the Council on Foreign Relations.

The New York Times
28 Jun 2014

With Surge of Chaos in Iraq, a Familiar Problem Knocks on Biden's Door

By MARK LANDLER

WASHINGTON — From the first summer of the Obama administration, Iraq has been considered Vice President Joseph R. Biden Jr.'s account. But when President Obama called a critical meeting on June 16 to confront the crisis that had suddenly erupted there, Mr. Biden was landing in Brazil to go to a World Cup soccer game.

Mr. Biden, who had been sent to mend the rift left by the National Security Agency's eavesdropping on Brazil's president, instead found himself stuck on Air Force Two for 90 minutes, dialing in to deliberate over an issue both he and the president thought they had left behind.

For a second-term vice president who had hoped to shift his foreign policy focus to new horizons in Latin America and Asia, the resurgence of chaos in Iraq is a decidedly mixed blessing.

It has plunged Mr. Biden into a familiar grind of frustrating phone calls with Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki, the recalcitrant Shiite leader with whom Mr. Obama has little contact. Yet the fact that Iraq is fracturing along sectarian lines could allow Mr. Biden to claim vindication for a concept he proposed in 2006 and was widely dismissed at the time: that Iraq should be split into three largely autonomous regions.

Either way, Iraq has again landed in Mr. Biden's lap. How it weathers this latest strife will factor heavily in the legacy of a vice president who has used his long history and robust views on Iraq to position himself as an influential member of Mr. Obama's war council.

For now, Mr. Biden is saying nothing publicly about a federal, three-state Iraq, in keeping with the administration's effort to prod the Iraqis to form a unity government. Speaking to reporters in Brazil, the vice president emphasized the need for cohesion, not partition.

"He has not given up," said Jake Sullivan, the vice president's national security adviser. "He thinks, even at this late stage, there is the possibility that the Kurds, Sunnis and Shia can get through this government formation process."

But another senior official was more blunt. "If Iraq is going to stay together, it is going to be close to the model he envisioned," said the official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the delicacy of the situation. "In putting together the government, there are going to be conversations about federalism and devolving more power to the local level."

In fact, the White House has quietly begun contingency planning for how the United States would deal with a scenario — considered likely by many officials — in which the three groups are not able to agree on a strong, inclusive government.

There are not many palatable options. Any partitioning of Iraq, analysts say, could lead to even greater bloodshed than Iraq has seen in recent days, with the Sunni militant group the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, seizing Mosul, Tikrit and other cities.

Moreover, none of the options being weighed by the administration involve sending in American soldiers to stabilize the situation. When Mr. Obama was winding down the war in 2011, Mr. Biden was among those who argued for leaving a smaller residual force behind — one that would be narrowly focused on counterterrorism.

Critics of the administration argue that this decision left Iraq vulnerable to the chaos that now afflicts it. To some, that outweighs whatever credit Mr. Biden deserves for recognizing the centrifugal forces in Iraq.

"What he was saying about federalism and semi-independent areas, I think there's nothing wrong with that kind of thinking," Senator John McCain, Republican of Arizona, said in an interview. "Obviously that was a de facto situation with the Kurds a long time ago. But very honestly, it pales in comparison to his zealous advocacy for getting everybody out."

Aides to Mr. Biden said it was the Iraqis who opposed keeping even a small American force. And a larger troop presence, they said, might not have prevented the gains made by the Sunni militants, since those troops would not have had a combat role.

The New York Times
8 Jul 2014

Iraqi Lawmakers to Reconvene in Effort to Form Government

By ALISSA J. RUBIN

BAGHDAD — The Iraqi Parliament on Tuesday set its next meeting for Sunday as it tries again to form a new government after a failed attempt last week.

While the effort to form a government continued, fighting in northern and western Sunni provinces continued with no decisive movement on either side, but with airstrikes on Sunni militant positions in Tikrit and moves by militants to take more villages in northeastern Salahuddin Province.

It was unclear whether there would be any progress on Sunday or enough lawmakers present to form a quorum.

Parliament's administrative office had told lawmakers on Monday that there would be no session until Aug. 12. That announcement was met with dismay by other nations, which have been urging Iraq to act quickly to form a government that reflects the country's diverse and often hostile religious sects and ethnic groups.

On Tuesday, the temporary speaker, Mahdi al-Hafith, announced that Parliament would attempt to meet on Sunday "in order to safeguard the public interest and continue to build democracy."

The first step under the Constitution is to elect a speaker, and within a month to name a president and two vice presidents. Two weeks after that, Parliament is required to choose a prime minister.

Though elected in April, Parliament has not yet formed a government, in part because there is antagonism toward Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki. There now seems to be a focused effort to remove Mr. Maliki and find an acceptable alternative. Mr. Maliki, however, is pursuing a third term and is using his position as commander in chief to portray himself as crucial to holding the army together.

There is no consensus candidate yet for prime minister.

In northern and western Iraq, both the Sunni militants led by the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, or ISIS, and Iraqi government forces attempted to make gains.

In Tikrit, the capital of Salahuddin Province, Iraqi forces bombed buildings they believed were ISIS positions, but also dropped leaflets urging Tikritis to support them and fight ISIS.

In Al Qaim, on the western Iraqi border with Syria, three witnesses said they saw a drone fly in from Syria and drop a bomb on the military headquarters in the town. In Samarra, a town north of Baghdad, a suicide bomber detonated himself near the headquarters of the security command center, killing five people and wounding four others, according to an officer in the command center.

The United Nations also made public on Tuesday a letter from the Iraqi ambassador to the United Nations that said the government had lost a former chemical weapons facility to “armed terrorist groups.”

The New York Times
7 Jul 2014

Fiddling While Iraq Burns

By CAROL GIACOMO

Iraqi politicians are acting as if their country weren't under mortal threat from Sunni extremists. Instead of quickly forming a government so leaders can concentrate on rallying the country to fight the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, the new parliament on Monday postponed its next session until Aug. 12.

That means at least five more weeks of political paralysis; of festering tensions among Iraq's Shiite, Sunni and Kurdish ethnic groups; and of potential disintegration of the Iraqi state as the insurgents make progress. Earlier today the commanding general of the Iraqi Army's Sixth Division died in a mortar attack west of Baghdad.

According to news reports, Iraq's various political camps have been unable to reach agreement on who should hold the three top government posts. Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki, a member of the Shiite majority, isn't helping matters by stubbornly insisting on a third term as prime minister — which even many within his own party oppose. Mr. Maliki's policies of favoring Shiites, oppressing Sunnis and marginalizing Kurds have helped ignite the catastrophe his country now faces.

The delay in choosing new leaders is a repudiation of Iraq's Shiite clergy, as well as the United States, the United Nations, and Iran, who have urged Iraqis to form an inclusive government that could unify the country and possibly hold it together.

Time is not on the Iraqis side. Gen. Martin Dempsey, chairman of the U.S. Joint Chiefs of Staff, told a news conference last week that while Iraqi government forces were “capable of defending Baghdad” they would find it difficult, without external support, to go on the offensive and retake territory held by ISIS.

The United States, which has sent 750 advisers to Iraq, is considering air strikes and other assistance but is awaiting the outcome of the government formation process before making a decision. It is hard to know if American involvement in the area could prove effective, but the administration is right to at least wait and see if the government in Baghdad will dedicate itself to representing all Iraqis, and calming the sectarian divisions that have allowed extremists to take root.

The New York Times
28 Jun 2014

Life in Iraq Grinds On, Whoever Is in Charge

By JAMES GLANZ

HIS name was Thamir, and he was a pool hustler. He was good enough that when a translator shouted in the pool hall that I wanted to meet the best player in Husayba, the gaggle of men parted, opening the way to him. Thamir grinned wryly, pressed an index finger against his chest and lifted his chin in that universal gesture: You want to talk to me?

I did want to talk to him, and when I did he bragged that he came to the pool hall only long enough to make what his family needed to get by — roughly \$10 a day, he reckoned — before taking the rest of the day off and enjoying the good life.

“Right now it is very good, very safe,” Thamir said, glancing at the handful of heavily armed United States Marines who had shown me up a narrow stairway to the pool hall.

The Iraqi district of Qaim, a fertile stretch of sheep herds and greenery along the Euphrates River that includes Husayba, a strategic border crossing with Syria, was overrun earlier this month by militants from the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, or ISIS, a Sunni-dominated extremist group. The loss of Qaim was a nightmarish turn for the Shiite-led Iraqi government, as the militants were likely to move directly down the river valley toward Baghdad.

Qaim and the vast Anbar desert around it certainly saw their share of bitter fighting after the American-led invasion of Iraq in 2003. But during my visit to Qaim four years later, in bleak stretches of that desert, at local town markets and around a camp so close to the border that a huge picture of Bashar al-Assad, the Syrian president, stared across a closed gateway, the Marines and I both saw something else: characters any American would recognize, seemingly aching to lead lives that we would consider happy and fairly run of the mill.

How is it possible that this Memphis-on-the-Euphrates could become part of the hinterland of a caliphate, or strict Islamic state, envisioned by ISIS? The journey that led to the second-floor pool hall may hold at least some of the answers.

The Marines were not naïve about the dualities of these desert people, nearly all of them Sunni and members of tribes that straddled the border as if it did not exist.

“Syraq,” one lieutenant colonel put it, merging the country names, as he showed me routes where tribes had smuggled hundreds of thousands of cigarettes over the border. The Marines could do so little about the cross-border smuggling that they seemed to accept it as an almost comedic inevitability. Another officer said that when his unit surprised one large group of smugglers, they dropped their loads and scattered — leaving a one-legged compatriot behind.

"I don't even think he lost a smile," the officer said. "It was more like, 'Ah, you caught me!' "

The Marines, having studied up on the tribes, often sounded like physicists discussing complex particle interactions. The Albu Mahal tribe had long dominated the area, the colonel said, but the 2003 invasion and its aftermath rocked the old order. Alliances and tensions among the Karbali, Hardan and Salmani tribes and a Qaeda group, the colonel said, were part of what sparked a major American military operation there in 2005.

That operation, called Steel Curtain, was described by American officials at the time as an effort to stanch the flow of foreign fighters from Syria. The underlying dynamic was something else, the colonel said: "What led to Steel Curtain was basically a tribal war."

Order was restored, as Albu Mahal allied itself with the American military, regained its primacy and helped keep the peace. How the tribes have reshuffled themselves now is anyone's guess, and the chaos can only be deepened by something else I encountered during my visit: oil.

Engineers had recently learned that the Akkas oil and gas field beneath the Anbar desert was far larger than previously known. I traveled with John R. Allen, then a brigadier general who was a leading commander in Anbar, to an exploratory wellhead in the open desert 20 miles southwest of Qaim. "What this does is, it gives Anbar and the Sunnis an economic future different from phosphate and cement," he said, referring to tumbledown factories in the area.

The dapper mayor of Qaim, Farhan Farhan, who was wearing a natty gray jacket and a black shirt on the day I met him, said, "If we use this petroleum, it will be enough for all the west of Iraq."

Those words take on a different cast now that the area has been infiltrated by militants who aim to create their own state and could presumably use some revenue and sources of energy. (Officials with Kogas, the South Korean company with a contract to develop the Akkas field, said Friday that the company had safely evacuated all its workers before the ISIS advance and believed that the militants were now in control of the area.)

Beyond the larger-scale drama of tribal animosities and oil I discovered on my visit in 2007, the simple grind of living in Husayba was visible on the street. During a walk with eight Marines through the souk, we ran across a man whose daughter was seriously ill but refused to take her to Baghdad for fear of their being killed by Shiite gangs. Shop owners moaned that the barricaded crossing kept them from shopping for supplies where they felt safe.

How a pool hustler fits into a caliphate, I don't pretend to know, but I hope Thamir is still separating his ten bucks a day from whichever suckers are currently wandering the souk. When we squeezed our way up the stairway to the pool hall that day, though, he didn't have to hustle much for us to see him as a guy we recognized from our hometowns who was a thread in the fabric of a functioning society.

You could make good money betting that when an occupier wants to believe that it may all be for the best, the occupied will see no percentage in letting on that it might be otherwise.

The New York Times
27 Jun 2014

While Iraq Burns

By THE EDITORIAL BOARD

In the face of a violent offensive by Sunni militants, Iraq's future as a unified state is becoming less and less likely. As the Sunni militants take hold of a large swath of northwest Iraq, the Kurds, who operate a semiautonomous province in northeast Iraq, are edging toward independence, leaving Shiites controlling Baghdad and regions in the south. Yet Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki seems to have no interest in finding a new way forward from a catastrophe his policies ignited.

In Baghdad this week, Secretary of State John Kerry pressed Mr. Maliki, who represents the Shiite majority, to form a national unity government that would share power more equitably among the Shiite, Sunni and Kurdish groups. That is perhaps the only way to forestall complete division of the country and even greater violence as the insurgents drive toward Baghdad.

Instead, Mr. Maliki has refused to make political concessions demanded by Sunnis and Kurds. His recalcitrance has raised concerns even among Shiites, some of whom are working with the Sunnis and Kurds to replace him. Over eight years, Mr. Maliki's arrests of Sunni opponents and his refusal to fully include them and the Kurds in Iraq's political life have fueled resentments that have allowed extremists to flourish.

On Wednesday, an offshoot of Al Qaeda known as the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, which has taken over the northwest region, attacked one of Iraq's largest air bases and was heading toward the Haditha Dam. The group is also fighting in Syria, with the aim of creating a caliphate straddling the two countries.

Mr. Maliki promised Mr. Kerry that next week Parliament would begin choosing a new government, based on the April 30 election results that gave his State of Law party the most seats. American and other Western officials have already indicated that they would prefer to see Mr. Maliki step down as prime minister. Meanwhile, the Kurds, who have run their own enclave since 1991 and have made it Iraq's most prosperous region, now see an opportunity to establish an independent Kurdistan.

The chaos of the militants' offensive gave the Kurds, backed by their peshmerga security forces, an opening on June 12 to seize the disputed city of Kirkuk, which has oil. It also prompted Masoud Barzani, the Kurdish leader, to revive the idea of independence, a move Mr. Kerry asked him to reconsider, with little apparent success.

For now, Mr. Kerry and other Western officials are still stressing the importance of preserving a unified Iraq. But no one should have any illusions. After three years of war, Syria has basically split along sectarian lines, and some experts see a similar future for Iraq, where the Iraqi Army so far has been incapable of protecting the country and is considered unlikely to dislodge ISIS.

Although President Obama has wisely ruled out a return of American ground troops, he has deployed 300 advisers (plus private security guards to protect them) to help the Iraqi Army

and to develop targets for potential military strikes against the militants. Obama administration officials have said any strikes will depend on factors like support from Iraq's political leaders and intelligence that identifies precise ISIS targets. But military advice and support won't accomplish much if Mr. Maliki and other Iraqi leaders refuse to join together to save their state.

The New York Times

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Iraq's Tangle of Insurgent Groups

Though ISIS has grown to be the most powerful militant group in Iraq, its foothold in the country relies on negotiating a shifting tangle of smaller groups and alliances. This is a snapshot of the active militant groups in provinces north and west of Baghdad, based on information from the Pentagon and other U.S. officials and reporting by Times journalists in Iraq.

NAQSHBANDIA ORDER/J.R.T.N.

Baathist

Active in: Diyala, Salahuddin

ISIS relationship: Fighting

Established in 2007, the group's reputed leader was a high-ranking deputy in Saddam Hussein's regime. The group is believed to have initially assisted ISIS in its push south from Mosul.

REVOLUTION BRIGADES

Baathist

Active in: Diyala, Anbar

ISIS relationship: Fighting in some areas

Formed by disaffected Iraqi Army officers who were left without jobs after the Americans dissolved the military in 2003.

ISLAMIC ARMY OF IRAQ

Salafist

Active in: Diyala, Salahuddin, Anbar

ISIS relationship: Periodic fighting

ISIS has targeted family members of the leadership of this group, which has long had a presence in Diyala and has been involved in past sectarian battles.

MUJAHEDeen ARMY

Salafist

Active in: Diyala, Salahuddin, Anbar

ISIS relationship: Truce

A nationalist Islamist group that advocates overthrowing the Iraqi government.

KHATA'IB aL-MUSTAPHA

Salafist

Active in: Diyala

ISIS relationship: Truce

Islamic militants who fight against the government.

ARMY OF MUHAMMAD

Salafist

Active in: Anbar

ISIS relationship: Allies

Islamic militants who fight against the government.

KHATA'IB TAWRAT AL-ASHREEN

Anti-government Sunni Tribe

Active in: Diyala, Salahuddin

ISIS relationship: Truce

Sunni tribes opposed to the Iraqi government.

ANSAR AL-ISLAM / ANSAR AL-SUNNA

Islamist Jihadist

Active in: Diyala

ISIS relationship: Fighting

An Al Qaeda-affiliated group that has led a number of deadly attacks in Iraq over the years.
